Loose Knit

By Theresa Rebeck

Character: Paula (African American) & Miles (Caucasian): a couple on a blind date, 30s
Setting: A sushi restaurant, the present

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: It's the natural state of existence. Thee has always been and always will be a hierarchy of power . . . Men vs women; white vs black, logical politics vs psychological reasoning . . . The sooner she accepts it the more content she will be . . . Tonight is the night to open her eyes.

ACTRESS: Hmmph! Some say that opposites attract, but on this particular blind date; the attraction quickly fades. Let's get it over with . . . .

Loose Knit by Theresa Rebeck

PAULA: I've never seen them do that before.

MILES: Excuse me?

PAULA: I've never seen a waiter serve sushi like that. Like an offering. It's quite - remarkable.

MILES: I know. It's a little embarrassing. They call it the Imperial Feast, and the show comes with it. Sort of like those waiters who sing to you in pizza joints.

PAULA: I didn't think you went to pizza joints.

MILES: I don't. I come here. (He starts to serve her.)

PAULA: I hope you don't mind my asking, but don't you find this all a bit. . . overstated?

MILES: Don't you like sushi? I love sushi.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

PAULA: That's not what I meant. It's just, most people I know would be uncomfortable with the politics of all this. I mean, I've had a wonderful time tonight; meeting the governor was really exciting, and the opening at the Whitney was nothing short of dazzling. But to tell the truth, I'm beginning to find this all a little unnerving.

MILES: Really? How so?

PAULA: Well. you know, all of it together is so - all right. Your air of patronage, the subservience of everyone in the restaurant, your car - I mean don't you guys read the newspaper? This sort of thing is going out of style.

MILES: Do you really think so?

PAULA: Yes. I do.

MILES: I think you'd be surprised. The imperialistic structures which seem to disturb you so much have stood at the heart of the American culture for centuries. In fact, these structures, and the assumptions they are built upon, are the very things which have made culture possible. In America and throughout the world.

PAULA: Well, that may be, but

MILES: Here, I think you'll appreciate this; it's a combination of abalone, salmon roe and mahi mahi. Only two people in the world know how to make it. It's exquisite, really.

PAULA: Thank you. (He places it on her plate and hands it to her, then makes a note in his notebook. As he interviews her, he continues to make notes.) What are you doing?

MILES: Just making a few notes to myself, that's all. It's a business habit. Annoying but harmless. I picked it up from my father.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

PAULA: (Friendly.) Really? What was he like?

MILES: No, no, no. I was warned about this. You're famous for this. No prying about my parents until the second date.

PAULA: You can't blame a girl for trying.

MILES: (Laughing.) I hope you don't mind my saying so, Paula, but this is the first time I've dated a woman of color. I find it quite stimulating.

PAULA: Really?

MILES: Don't you think so?

PAULA: Well, I've dated white men before.

MILES: So the novelty's worn off.

PAULA: I guess.

MILES: (He writes this down.) Do you have many white friends?

PAULA: Yes. Do you?

MILES: Well, it's less of an issue for me, isn't it?

PAULA: You tell me.

MILES: (Laughing.) Therapists. All I meant was, clearly, it's important for blacks to assimilate themselves into the high culture. Which you seem to have accomplished admirably.

PAULA: What?

MILES: An attractive black woman achieves a position of authority in a predominantly white profession? That looks like assimilation to me.

PAULA: Yes, well, just for the record, I'm not particularly interested in being assimilated into the "high" culture.

MILES: You're not?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

PAULA: No. Most of my "friends" are black. And, as you may or may not realize, my family is black. You might want to write that down, too.

MILES: Do you see them often?

PAULA: Yes. I do.

MILES: How often?

PAULA: Often enough.

MILES: And your "black friends?" How often do you see them?

PAULA: I don't keep track of how often I - .

MILES: And your white friends? How often do you see them?

PAULA: Often.

MILES: More often than you see your black friends?

PAULA: (Pause, cold.) Maybe.

MILES: That's the beauty of America, isn't it? Social mobility. (He writes this down.)

PAULA: Okay. What's going on here?

MILES: We're trying to get to know each other.

PAULA: Is that what we're doing?

MILES: Don't you want to know me, Paula? Because I find you fascinating.

PAULA: You're pretty fascinating yourself, Miles.

MILES: Thank you. So. You're a psychologist How many patients do you have?

(Beat. Cautiously, Paula decides to answer.)

PAULA: They're not patients, they're clients.

MILES: White?

PAULA: Would it make a difference if they were?

MILES: You tell me. You're the one who doesn't want to be assimilated.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

PAULA: (Pause.) Yes. Most of them are white.

MILES: Do you like them?

PAULA: What is that supposed to mean?

MILES: It's a simple question.

PAULA: No, it's not

MILES: I was just wondering how it felt to have white people come in and complain to you all the time.

PAULA: It feels just fine.

MILES: I think you're being coy.

PAULA: And I think you're attacking me.

MILES: I'm just trying to get to know you, Paula. And I really am interested in the whole therapeutic enterprise.

PAULA: Then maybe you should try it. I know a couple of people who might be able to help you with this notebook thing.

MILES: (Smiling a little.) I'll think about it. So, how long, on the average, do you work with any given client? One year? Two? Five? Ten?

PAULA: Yes.

MILES: Have they gotten better?

PAULA: Oh, my God. . .

MILES: Is that a delicate question? I'm sorry. I just don't understand why someone would need your services for ten years. I mean, it's a treatment, right? What good is a treatment if it doesn't make you better?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

PAULA: (Steely.) Well, Miles, some people have been terribly damaged by life. Their souls have been - wounded, whether by their family, or events, or just the world

MILES: Well, Paula, I'm sure you're good at what you do, but I'm not convinced that talking to you is going to heal my soul or even make me a successful member of society. I've just never understood why anyone thinks that discussing their problems will make them go away.

PAULA: No one thinks that.

MILES: Don't they?

PAULA: No.

MILES: I thought they did.

PAULA: Well, and so what if they do? Sometimes we all need someone to talk to just to - to get a perspective on things. The world's a hard place. Once in a while, even the best of us needs an ear, and a little shot of compassion. Is that so awful?

MILES: But you don't provide compassion. You provide a service.

PAULA: I also provide compassion.

MILES: If you require a person to pay for it, is it still compassion?

PAULA: Why are you attacking me?

MILES: Why do you see this as an attack? On the contrary, I have nothing but admiration for the shrewdness of your whole enterprise. You convince people they're dependent on you for their happiness, then you charge them for that dependency. It's brilliant.

PAULA: That is not what I do!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MILES: Of course not. I'm sorry if I touched a nerve. (He writes.) Have you tried the eel?

PAULA: No.

MILES: You should. (Pause.) Go ahead, try it. (Pause.) Try it. (She reaches for it. He smiles.)

PAULA: All right, Miles. All right. I think we've talked about me quite enough for one evening. I'd like to hear about you. Why don't you tell me what kind of dreams you have?

MILES: You're interested in my dreams?

PAULA: Very.

MILES: (Pause.) All right. (Pause.) There's one I have where I'm in my office above the city, and there's a document in the computer that I can't get out. So I look in my desk for the key to the computer and it looks like a knife, or a letter opener; it's quite sharp, but just as I'm about to put it into the computer a white rat comes along and steals it out of my hand. So I chase her up and down the halls, and then I hear her behind me, so I turn, and hold out my hand, and the knife is in it - the key, I mean - but it's a different rat, a black rat, only now she's covered in blood because I've stabbed her. Because I had the key all along. (Pause.) Actually, I've had that dream several times.

PAULA: Really.

MILES: Do you know what it means?

PAULA: No. No. I have no idea. (She stares at him. Blackout.)

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Theresa Rebeck
Book: Complete Plays 1989-1998
ISBN: 978-1575251721
Publisher: Smith & Kraus Publishers
Date (Month/Year): March 1999

AWARD HISTORY

National Qualifier - Prior to 2001

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY